

A FIRST RECKONING, KEYED AND READY TO RUN

BLOOD & GRIT

A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF THE HAUNTED
FRONTIER

THE SALT AT COFFIN WELLS

Module I · A one-night adventure for four souls at 1st level · Version 1.2

Coffin Wells is dying of a fever that is not a fever. Four nights remain.





"A banker will tell you a debt is a number. It is not. It is a thing you have promised, and out here the things you promise come to collect in person."

— MARSHAL ADELIA CRUZ, CALVARY CROSSING



"They buried Tom Pell on the Tuesday. He was home by the Friday, and he was hungry, and I have not slept since."

— HANNAH PELL, DEPOSITION TAKEN AT COFFIN WELLS



Blood & Grit · Module I · The Salt at Coffin Wells · Version 1.2 · For the Keeper Alone

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What This Is



Run it loose. The map is not the country and the key is not the night.

— A NOTE PINNED INSIDE THE COVER OF THE FIRST PRINTING



One night at the table, for four souls at 1st level, in the country the Keeper's Book calls Perdition Basin. It wants three to four hours and it wants no preparation beyond reading it once. Every creature in it is printed here in full, so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf.

It is built to do the thing a first session most often fails to do. It opens as an honest western (a town, a bar, a man buying a round), and it turns the note slowly enough that the players are the ones who notice. By the end of the second act they should be frayed and low on Nerve and beginning to understand that this is not the western they thought they rode into.

What You Need

The Player's Book for the souls, and this. The Keeper's Book is useful and not required; where this module leans on one of its rules it says which and where. If you are running GritKeeper at the table, the posse, the tracker and the clock below all go straight in.

What It Teaches, and in What Order

Three things, one per act, and never two at once.

- **Act One teaches the Dread Check.** One check, DC 13, on a graveyard with the dirt wrong. Soft on purpose. A table's first Dread Check should be one they mostly pass, so they learn the shape of it before it costs them.
- **Act Two teaches that some things do not stop.** Three Risen, in a house with the supper still on the table. This is the fight where somebody empties a gun into a thing that keeps coming, and it is the whole reason the module exists.
- **Act Three teaches that shooting is not the answer.** It is not a harder fight. It is a different kind of problem, and the module is emphatic about this because the engine is: see What the Night Costs.

BEFORE YOU RUN IT

Read the three acts and nothing else. The Cast and the creature entries are reference; look at them when the table looks at them. A Keeper who has memorised this module runs it worse than a Keeper who has read it once, because the first one is delivering a night and the second one is having one.

The Truth of It

For the Keeper alone. Nothing on this page is known to anyone the posse will meet, except where it says so.

Six weeks ago Josiah Vane, who holds the note on most of Coffin Wells and on none of it profitably, rode out to the old mission ground east of town with a shovel and a rumour. The rumour was silver: that the Spanish padres had put their plate in the ground when they abandoned San Clavo, and that the marked grave on the mission's east side was where. The grave was marked. It was marked because it was staked and salted, and the padres had written on the stone in a language Vane could not read and did not trouble to have read.

He dug. He found no silver. He found a stake through a chest and he pulled it out, because a man who has dug four hours in the dark will pull on anything.

What sat up made him an offer, and he took it. Blood for the town, fed quietly, a little at a time, out at the homesteads where nobody counts. In exchange he lives, and he is made rich, and he does not have to watch. He has kept the bargain for six weeks. He is past being able to stop and well past being able to confess, and he is drinking a great deal.

The Fever

There is no fever. The outlying homesteads are being fed on, and the ones who die of it do not stay dead; they get up two or three days after burial, hungry and slow and wearing the face their family knew. Coffin Wells has buried nine people in six weeks and dug up four of them again without saying so out loud.

The Clock

This is the pressure and it should be felt rather than announced. The thing at the mission grows stronger every night it feeds. Tonight is the fourth night of the fourth week and there are four nights left in which a stake will still hold it.

The Fourth Night

4 segments

Fill a segment each time the posse spends a scene on something other than the fever — a night in the saloon, a day riding to the county seat, an afternoon on Vane's books. At four, the thing has fed enough that stake and salt no longer bind it, and the module's ending changes: see The Box.

KEEPER

Do not let a player read this page and do not answer questions about it in the voice you use for rules. Everything here is discoverable in play, and every route to it is keyed in the acts. The one thing that is not discoverable is the count of nights; that is yours, and it is meant to be felt as the town getting worse rather than as a number going up.

The Hook, and Getting Them There

Any reason that puts the posse in Coffin Wells at dusk will serve, and the module does not care which. Four that work:

- **Cattle.** They are driving forty head to the railhead at Calvary Crossing and Coffin Wells is the last water before the dry stretch.
- **Paper.** One of them is carrying a dodger with a name on it, and the name was last seen here.
- **Kin.** A letter from somebody's sister stopped coming in April. She homesteaded eleven miles out, at a place called Pell's.
- **Thirst.** They have been eleven days in the saddle and there is a town.

The sun is most of the way down when the road bends and gives you the town. Coffin Wells is one street, forty buildings, and a water tower with the paint gone off the north face. Every shutter you can see is closed. It is not late enough for that.

The gate is that the shutters are shut too early. Let them notice it, and let nobody explain it. A man crossing the street looks at them and keeps walking. The livery boy takes the horses and does not ask where they have come from, which is the only question anybody in a town this size ever asks.

The Marshal Wants Them Gone

Marshal Adelia Cruz will find them inside the hour, and she is not hostile. She is tired and frightened and she has buried nine people, and she has worked out that strangers in a town with a fever either catch it or start a panic. She asks them to be gone by morning. She will not make them.

She is the module's way in and she will become their ally in Act Two, so do not play her as an obstacle. Play her as a woman doing arithmetic she does not like the answer to.

Marshal Adelia Cruz

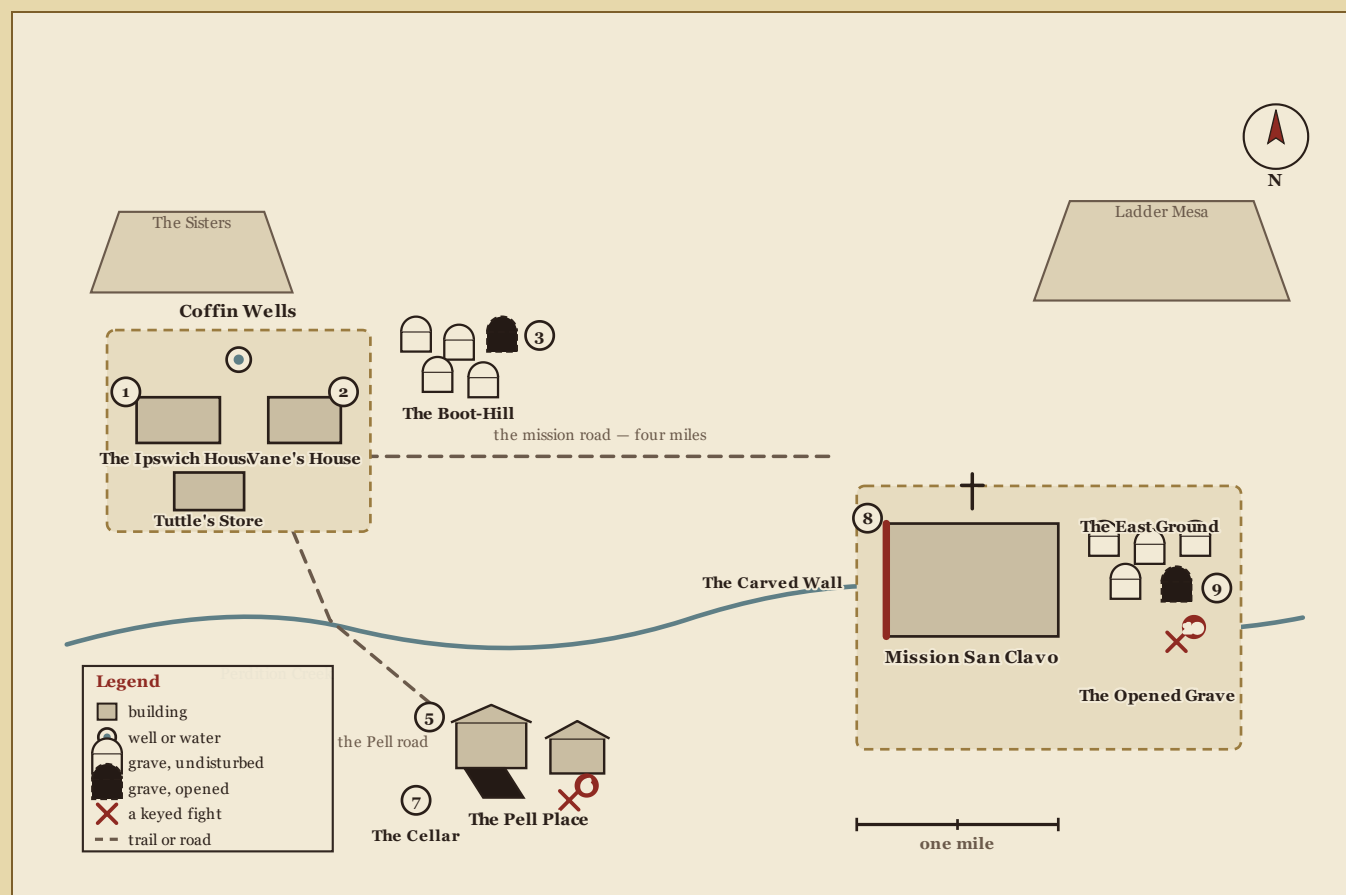
WANTS the burying to stop, and to not be the one who has to name why it is happening

LEVER she will trade anything she knows for anyone who will ride out to the Pell place, because she has been three times and cannot make herself go a fourth

"Nine in six weeks. In a town of four hundred. You do that sum and then tell me it is a fever."

The Ground

Every numbered place below is a keyed scene, and the number on the map is the number in the margin of the act it belongs to.



The Night at Coffin Wells — the town, the Pell road and the mission ground, with the keyed scenes pinned where they happen

What the Shape of It Does

Four miles of the mission road, and everything in this module hangs off that distance. It is an hour on a tired horse in the dark. It is short enough that the posse can go out and come back in one night, and long enough that going out is a decision.

- **The town is west and the answer is east.** Every scene in Act One faces the wrong way on purpose. The boot-hill is the first thing on the map that points the other direction.
- **The Pell place is off the road.** South, down a track, out of sight of anywhere. That is why nobody has counted what has been happening to the homesteads.
- **The mission is on open ground and the graveyard is on its east side,** which is the side the sun comes up on. Act Three ends at dawn, in the open, and the map is quietly telling the Keeper where to stand everyone.

KEEPER

Hand the map to the table in Act One. Nothing on it is a secret. A stranger riding into Coffin Wells can see the mission road and be told where it goes. The download beside it prints on one sheet.

Act One – The Ordinary West

Aim for forty minutes. One Dread Check, DC 13, and no monster.

This act has one job: be a real town, so that the second act has something to ruin. Play the scenes below in whatever order the posse walks into them, and cut the act the moment they decide to ride out to Pell's.

1. The Ipswich House

The saloon, and the only lit building on the street. Eleven people in it, all of them local, all of them talking about the fever and none of them using the word. The barkeep, Ozzie Vane, is Josiah's cousin and knows nothing.

Somebody will mention the Pell place inside five minutes. Somebody else will change the subject.

2. Josiah Vane Buys a Round

He arrives twenty minutes in, and he is charming, and he is drunk in the careful way of a man who has been drunk every night for six weeks. He buys. He asks where they are headed and he is very pleased to hear it is anywhere else.

If the posse mentions the fever he will agree that it is dreadful and steer hard. If they mention the mission ground he will go quiet for exactly one beat too long, and then be charming about it. **That beat is the whole clue.** Do not underline it. A player who catches it has earned the third act.

Josiah Vane

WANTS to not be found out, and under that, to be forgiven, which he has stopped believing is available

LEVER he cannot stand to be alone after dark and will invent reasons to keep company

"The country takes people. That is all it has ever done. You would think we would have learned to stop being surprised."

3. The Boot-Hill

Up the rise north of town, and worth walking to if anyone thinks of it. Nine fresh graves. Four of them have been dug up *from the inside*: the dirt is heaped outward, the boards are pushed out rather than in, and one coffin lid is lying eleven feet from its hole.

The dirt on four of these is wrong. It is not sunk the way settled ground sinks. It is heaped out and away, in a ring, the way dirt lies when something has come up through it.

Dread Check, DC 13, Will save. Tier I loss on a failure. This is the table's first, and it is soft deliberately. Call it out loud, name the save, and let a failure sting a little without costing anybody the night.

4. Small Wrongnesses

Scatter two or three of these and no more. They are seasoning.

- No dog in town will go east of the water tower. They will not be led, and one will bite.
- Hannah Pell's sister-in-law says, once, quietly, that Tom Pell came home on the Friday after they buried him on the Tuesday. She will not say it twice and denies it if pressed.
- The general store has sold out of salt. All of it. Six weeks running.

KEEPER

End the act when they ride for Pell's, whether the Marshal asked them to or their own curiosity did. If they will not go, have the Marshal come and get them at midnight: Hannah Pell walked into town on foot, eleven miles, barefoot, and will not say what from.

Act Two – The Wrong Note Answers

Aim for an hour. Two Dread Checks and the fight the module is built around.

5. The Pell Place

Eleven miles of nothing, and then a house with its door standing open and no light in it. The supper is on the table and has been there long enough to have stopped smelling of supper. Four chairs. Three of them pushed back.

Dread Check, DC 16, Will save. Tier I loss. Nobody has met anything yet, which is the point: the house does this on its own.

The house gives up three things to anyone who looks:

- The third chair was not pushed back. It was knocked over and set upright again, badly.
- There is a Bible on the sideboard with a page torn out of Leviticus. The torn page is under the door, folded, wedged as a shim. Somebody was trying to keep the door shut.
- The salt cellar is empty and the ring of salt on the floor around the youngest child's bed is unbroken. That child is alive, upstairs, and has not spoken in four days.

6. The Dead Getting Up

They come out of the barn, and one of them is Tom Pell, who was buried on the Tuesday and is wearing what he was buried in.

SIGN OF IT. Where the dead were buried wrong or buried angry — mass graves, massacre grounds, potter's fields, the floor of a burned church. They rise at full dark and the first night is always the worst.

Three Risen. Full entry under What Walks Here. Play them slow and play them relentless. They do not flinch, they do not take cover, and a shot that

would put a man down puts one of them on the ground for a round and then it gets back up.

RUNNING IT

This is the lesson fight and it must be won. The engine says a fresh posse clears it two times in twelve if they only shoot, and ten times in twelve if somebody thinks of fire, the barn door as a bottleneck, or the lamp oil on the shelf. Put the lamp oil where they can see it. If the fight turns badly, Marshal Cruz arrives on the third round: she followed them, and she has a shotgun and a bad conscience.

7. The Cellar

Hannah Pell is down there, bled thin and half-turned, and she is still herself for now. She knows what is happening to her. She asks them to see to it before she stops being able to ask.

Dread Check, DC 16, Will save. Tier II loss. This one is meant to cost.

She has been down here two days and she has thought it all the way through. "There is a shotgun on the pegs by the stair," she says. "I would do it myself but my hands have gone wrong and I do not trust them to be quick."

KEEPER

There is no correct answer here and the module refuses to supply one. A mercy costs a Dread Check and nothing else. A hope (taking her to town, tying her, riding for a doctor) costs a segment off the clock and puts her in Act Three, where she will turn, and where what she does then is on them. Both are playable. Neither is punished. Whatever they choose should follow at least one of them into the next module.

On Tom Pell's body: a scrap of worked silver, old, stamped with a cross and a word in Latin. It came off a reliquary. It points east, to the mission.

Act Three – The Reckoning

Aim for an hour. One Dread Check, one problem, and a sunrise.

8. Mission San Clavo, the East Ground

Roofless, burned in 1811, and the graveyard on the east side is the only part anybody has kept the brush off. One grave is open. The stake is lying beside the hole with six weeks of weather on it, and there is a shovel with a banker's initials burned into the handle.

The carvings on the standing wall of the nave are the answer, and they are in three panels, and they are the padres telling whoever comes next what they did and how.

- **First panel.** A figure pinned to the ground with a spear through the chest.
- **Second panel.** The same figure with its head off, and the head in a fire.
- **Third panel.** Men pouring something from sacks in a ring around the grave. The sacks are the only thing in three panels the carver bothered to render in detail, and what is coming out of them is grains.

THE WHOLE CLIMAX

Give them the panels early and let them work. Pin, take the head, burn it, salt the ground. That is the Bestiary's answer, printed under the entry, and it is the only thing that ends this. A posse that reads the wall in Act Three and solves it under fire has earned the best moment this module has. A posse that walks past the wall gets a very bad night.

9. Vane, at the Grave

He is here. He came to feed it, or to beg it, or the posse dragged him, and it makes very little difference which. He is done pretending and he will tell them everything in about ninety seconds if anyone asks

him a direct question, because he has been waiting six weeks for somebody to make him.

He does not know the answer. He never read the wall. That is his whole character in one sentence and it is worth saying out loud at the table if it lands.

10. The Thing Out of the Grave

Dread Check, DC 18, Will save. Tier III loss, and it is its regard that does it rather than its appearance; it looks at each of them in turn, the way a man looks at stock.

SIGN OF IT. Old houses with the curtains always drawn, played-out estates, the respectable parts of a town with a quiet problem. It keeps a lair — a grave, a cellar, a coffin of home soil — and must return to it before dawn.

Full entry under What Walks Here. Run the confrontation in the dark of the nave: the cold coming off it, the way it goes up a wall, the way it does not hurry.

READ THIS BEFORE YOU RUN IT

This cannot be shot down and the module means that literally. Twelve posses were run at this fight on the engine and not one of them won it with guns; see What the Night Costs for the count. Do not soften the fight to make it winnable. Make the wall readable instead, and let the answer be a thing they do rather than a roll they pass. Pin it: the stake is right there in the dirt. Take the head. Burn it. Salt the grave. Every one of those is an action anyone can take, and none of them is an attack roll against Defense 18.

11. The Sky Goes Gray

The escape valve, and it is always available. If the posse is pinned and dying, the east goes gray and the thing leaves, because it must. It costs them the ending and it does not cost them the night. A Keeper who uses this has not failed; the module is built with it in.

The Cast

A want, a lever, and a line, per the Keeper's Book Ch. VIII.

Ozzie Vane, barkeep

WANTS his cousin to stop coming in and drinking like that where people can see

LEVER he is loyal and he is not stupid, and those two are pulling opposite ways

"Josiah has had a bad year. That is all it is. A man is allowed a bad year."

Hannah Pell

WANTS to be seen to before she stops being herself

LEVER she is the only person in the module who will tell the posse the whole truth unprompted

"It was not a fever and you know it was not. Say it, so I know somebody said it."

Elder Bram Tuttle, who keeps the store

WANTS to be paid what he is owed and to be left out of it

LEVER he has sold six weeks of salt to somebody and he knows exactly who, and he will say for money

"Salt is salt. A man buys what he buys. I keep a store, not a diary."

The Pell child, nine, unnamed on purpose

WANTS nothing that can be put into words yet

LEVER she has not spoken in four days and she drew the thing on the wall of the barn in charcoal, twice, from memory, and it is a good likeness

"__"

KEEPER

Name the child at the table, in play, and let a player do it if one offers. A person the posse names is a person the posse comes back for, and this module is the first of three.

What Walks Here

Printed in full so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf. These entries are generated from the same file the app reads, so they cannot drift from the book they came out of.

The Risen

The Risen

Tier I · Tier I · the shambling dead

DEFENSE 12

BLOOD 14

SPEED shuffling (half)

SAVES Fort +6, Ref +0, Will +2

ATTACKS grasping hands +4 (1d6+2 and grab); bite +4 (1d4+2)

SPECIAL Does not stop. Ignores pain, fear, and being bloodied; immune to anything worked on a living mind.

DREAD DC 16, 1d6 (the first time the dead get up)

PUTTING IT DOWN Break the body past use or take the head; salt and fire end it for good.

Three of them at the Pell place, and one is Tom Pell. Play them slow. The horror of a Risen is not that it is fast.

The Nightwalker

The Nightwalker

Tier III · Tier III · the vampire dead

DEFENSE 18

BLOOD 44

SPEED fast; climbs sheer

SAVES Fort +11, Ref +9, Will +8

ATTACKS seizing grasp +9 (1d8+4 and grab); bite (vs. grabbed/helpless) +9 (2d6+4 and drain 1d6 Blood, healing as much)

SPECIAL Cold blood. Heals 5 Blood each turn unless burned or in sunlight; its regard frightens (Will DC 16). It cannot cross an uninvited threshold, running water, or noon.

DREAD DC 16, 1d6 (1d10 caught feeding)

PUTTING IT DOWN Pin it, stake it through the heart with seasoned wood, take the head and burn it, and salt the grave.

One, at the opened grave. Read its Putting It Down line twice before you run Act Three; it is the act's solution and it is printed right there.

WHY THE APP WILL ARGUE WITH YOU

On the safe-table rule. A Nightwalker is Tier III and a 1st-level posse is Tier 1, which is two Tiers over, so by the Keeper's Book Ch. IV this horror is sign and spoor rather than a fight, and GritKeeper will offer to put it on the trail instead of the field if you build it there. That is correct and this module does not override it. Act Three is not a fight the posse wins by fighting. It is a thing in the room with them while they do the four things the wall told them to do.

What the Night Costs

Every number on this page came out of the game's own engine. Twelve posses (a Gunhand, a Preacher, a Mountain Man and a Sawbones, built by the generator, at 1st level) were run through all three acts on the same rules library the app runs on, with the Bestiary's numbers for every foe and the book's dice for every roll. The runs are seeded and reproduce.

They were run twice over: once *cold*, with no recovery between acts and no Grit spent and no Sign or Miracle worked, and once *tended*, with the posse back to half Blood between acts. The point of the second was to find out whether the night is an attrition problem.

FIGHT	TIER	CLEARED	BROKE OFF	ROUNDS	POSSE HITS	ITS HITS
The dead getting up (Act Two)	I	2 of 12	8 of 12	1.6	31%	49%
The Nightwalker (Act Three)†	III	0 of 2	2 of 2	2.0	13%	75%

† So few posses got this far that the rates on this row are a handful of fights rather than a rate. Read the count; treat the percentages as an anecdote.

Read the second row and then read it again. Twelve posses, cold and tended both, and the Nightwalker was never once put down by shooting it. Giving the posse back half its Blood between every act changed that count by nothing, which is how you know it is not an attrition problem. Twelve Strikes a round at rising MAP land about one time in eight against Defense 18, and the thing hits back three times in four.

KEEPER

So the module says it plainly: Act Three is not a fight. It is a room with a monster in it and four things written on the wall. Pin it, take the head, burn it, salt the grave. A posse doing those four things under fire is a posse having the best twenty minutes this module has to offer. A posse trading Strikes with it is a posse the numbers above are about.

On the Act Two fight

Two clears in twelve looks alarming and is not. That row is a posse that only shoots, standing in the open, in a yard, against three things that do not stop. The same fight with the barn door as a bottleneck, or with the lamp oil used, or with the Marshal arriving on round three, is a fight a fresh posse wins comfortably, and every one of those is keyed into scene 6 for exactly this reason.

What the number is really telling you is the shape of the lesson: **this game does not reward standing still and firing**. Act Two is where a table learns that, cheaply, against Tier I. Act Three is where it matters.

Scaling the Night

- **A bigger or bolder posse.** Add a fourth Risen in Act Two. Give Vane two hired guns at the mission. Let the Nightwalker open Act Three from above rather than from the grave.
- **A smaller or greener posse.** Two Risen. Have the wall panels be plainer: a carved word, in English, put there by a later hand. Run the Nightwalker fed and slow: Defense 16 and no regard, if the posse reaches the mission on the first night.
- **If the dice turn cruel.** The dawn is always one scene away. Use it.

The Box, and What Comes After

However it ends, give it weight before anybody rolls anything else.

If they put it down

Coffin Wells lives. Nine people are still dead and four of them had to be put down twice, and the posse has a legend and a banker to hang or to pity. Let the town be grateful in the awkward way a town is grateful to strangers who saw it at its worst.

If it gets away

Or if the fourth segment filled and the stake no longer held. Do not run this as a failure. Run it as a thread: a town half-saved, a survivor who saw too much, and a debt the dark considers unpaid. It has a name for each of them now, which is worse than being hunted.

Whatever happened in the cellar

It follows one of them. Pick the soul who was closest to the decision and let it turn up in a dream, once, three sessions from now, with no mechanical effect at all. This module is the first of three and that is the thread the other two pull on.



A first night is a promise. Keep it honest and keep it frightening, and they will follow you into a hundred more.

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER, QUOTED IN THE KEEPER'S BOOK



What comes next

Module II, *A Face Not His Own*, is a relay station forty miles north and about a year later, for a posse at 3rd level. It is the same country and it does not require this one.

Index

Every person, place and thing in this night, and the page it waits on.



Scene numbers run 1–11 across the three acts and are keyed in the margin of each, and on the map in The Ground.

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